

WC 2026 Youth Training Report

Where the starting-lineup players train between ages 5 and 16?

Data through 75 completed matches · July 5, 2026

Completed matches	Unique starters	Unique training countries	Unique training clubs
75	754	53	983

Top 20 Training Countries

Unique starters counts each player once for every country where they trained, regardless of how long they spent there.

Weighted starters allocates each player as a fraction across countries in proportion to the years they spent training there between ages 5 and 16 — for example, a player who trained 8 years in France and 4 years in Spain contributes 0.67 to France and 0.33 to Spain. See Appendix 1 for the full counting rule.

#	Country	Unique starters	Weighted starters
1	France	70	60.01
2	Netherlands	49	38.79
3	England	49	33.18
4	Germany	42	27.32
5	Spain	38	27.31
6	United States	31	16.49
7	Belgium	28	20.36
8	Argentina	26	18.25
9	Czechia	24	17.00
10	Portugal	23	16.32
11	Norway	22	15.00
12	Croatia	21	15.70
13	Sweden	21	13.81
14	Austria	20	18.30
15	Türkiye	19	14.13
16	Brazil	18	15.12
17	Switzerland	17	14.00
18	Japan	17	13.19
19	Australia	17	12.17
20	Paraguay	17	10.35

Top 20 Training Clubs

Same year-share method as above, applied at club level. Players who moved between clubs are split across each club in proportion to time spent there.

#	Club	Country	Unique starters	Weighted starters
1	Anderlecht	Belgium	10	5.76
2	Paris Saint-Germain	France	10	4.59
3	Barcelona	Spain	10	4.48
4	Ajax	Netherlands	9	5.66
5	Dinamo Zagreb	Croatia	9	4.78
6	Hajduk Split	Croatia	9	3.86
7	PSV	Netherlands	8	4.90
8	Bayern Munich	Germany	8	4.54
9	Independiente del Valle	Ecuador	8	3.88
10	Manchester City	England	8	3.50
11	Benfica	Portugal	7	3.50
12	Genk	Belgium	7	1.38
13	Chelsea	England	6	3.91
14	Slavia Prague	Czechia	6	3.80
15	Rennes	France	6	3.46
16	Lyon	France	6	2.87
17	Fulham	England	6	2.84
18	Cerro Porteño	Paraguay	6	2.49
19	Al Ahly	Egypt	5	4.00
20	Manchester United	England	5	3.13

Local-Trained Ratio by National Team

Percentage of each team's tracked starters classified as locally trained. A player is locally trained if they have fewer than 5 foreign-country years on record. For players with no year data, classification is based solely on their club's country. Sorted from highest to lowest.

National team	Tracked starters	Locally trained	Local ratio
Austria	16	16	100%
Brazil	15	15	100%
Egypt	15	15	100%
England	17	17	100%
Jordan	14	14	100%
Netherlands	13	13	100%
Portugal	14	14	100%
Saudi Arabia	15	15	100%
South Africa	16	16	100%
Sweden	14	14	100%
Switzerland	16	16	100%
Uruguay	13	13	100%
Uzbekistan	17	17	100%
Czechia	26	25	96%
Norway	21	20	95%
Australia	17	16	94%
Belgium	17	16	94%
Spain	16	15	94%
IR Iran	15	14	93%
Korea Republic	14	13	93%
New Zealand	13	12	92%
Argentina	21	19	90%
Canada	17	15	88%
Japan	17	15	88%
Mexico	17	15	88%
Paraguay	16	14	88%
Scotland	16	14	88%
France	15	13	87%
Panama	15	13	87%

USA	21	18	86%
Ecuador	13	11	85%
Germany	13	11	85%
Croatia	24	20	83%
Colombia	14	11	79%
Iraq	16	12	75%
Côte d'Ivoire	15	11	73%
Qatar	15	11	73%
Haiti	14	10	71%
Ghana	16	11	69%
Senegal	16	11	69%
Cabo Verde	18	11	61%
Türkiye	25	15	60%
Bosnia and Herzegovina	18	10	56%
Tunisia	16	9	56%
Algeria	16	6	38%
Morocco	15	4	27%
DR Congo	14	3	21%
Curaçao	13	2	15%

Appendix 1 — Data Conditions and Counting Rules

Data sources

- **Starting XIs:** Wikipedia 2026 FIFA World Cup group and knockout-stage pages, scraped via BeautifulSoup. Each starting-XI row is linked to its match section URL.
- **Youth-club histories:** Wikipedia player infobox 'Youth career' section, fetched per player. Year spans and club names are parsed directly from the infobox table.
- **Club countries:** Inferred from each linked club's Wikipedia page lead text and categories using phrase-pattern matching.

Age window

Only training that overlaps the age range 5–16 is included. If a Wikipedia source gives a spell of 2008–2015 for a player born in 2000, that is converted to ages 8–15 and clipped to the 5–16 window.

Counting rule for players who moved

Each player's contribution is split across clubs and countries in proportion to the number of years they spent at each during ages 5–16. For example, a player who trained 8 years in France and 4 years in Spain contributes 0.67 to France and 0.33 to Spain. Where no year data is available, an equal split across clubs is used as a fallback.

Confidence tiers

- **Medium:** year span extracted from Wikipedia infobox; age estimates calculated from the player's birth year.
- **Low (fallback):** only a club name was available with no year span. The club is counted in unique starters but contributes 0 to weighted starters.
- **Unresolved:** 2 players have no usable youth section on Wikipedia. They are excluded from all rankings.

Known limitations

- The tournament was still in progress on the data collection date (2026-07-05). Knockout matches from the Round of 16 onwards are partially included.
- Club-country assignment is automated and may misclassify youth academies with ambiguous Wikipedia pages.
- Multi-country starters (104) are split across countries; multi-club starters (369) are split across clubs.
- Country backfill covers 1430 of 1430 youth-club rows. Rows without a country are excluded from country rankings only.

Players with no training data

The following 2 starters have no rows in the youth training table and are excluded from all rankings. Youth history still needs to be researched for these players.

Player	National team
Ivan Šunjić	Bosnia and Herzegovina
Pavel Šulc	Czechia

Source data

Collected data for this report can be found at: github.com/lorihe/WC2026-youth-clubs/tree/main/data

900+ youth clubs weren't easy to trace. If you spot an error or have a better source, comments are genuinely appreciated.